INKVERSE

Read. Create. Get paid.

Go-Live Steps: Deploy & Make It Real

Everything you personally need to do, in order, with exact values to copy
Owner checklist - 2026-10-14

Read this first

The code is finished, tested (48 automated checks) and already pushed to your GitHub repository. What remains can only be done by you, because it needs your personal accounts, passwords, bank details and legal identity. This guide lists those steps in order. Total time: about 2-3 hours, plus waiting for Stripe account approval.

Already done in code	Only you can do
Full website, API, real-time chat, moderation, admin console	Create the Render, Stripe, email and domain accounts
Stripe Checkout + signed webhook (coins credited once, amount-checked)	Paste your secret keys into Render (never into the code or GitHub)
Password-reset emails (needs an SMTP login)	Verify your business/bank with Stripe
Daily automatic database backups, health check, security headers	Pay creators (PayPal/bank) and click "Mark paid"
Render Blueprint (render.yaml), Dockerfile, Terms + Privacy templates	Legal review, DMCA agent registration, taxes

Costs (verify on each provider's pricing page): Render Starter web service about $7/month plus a small monthly charge for the 1 GB persistent disk. Stripe takes a fee per payment (commonly 2.9% + 30 cents in the US). Domain about $10-15/year. An SMTP email provider is usually free at low volume. The free Render plan will NOT work: it erases the database on every restart.

Business note: because Stripe's fixed 30-cent fee is large on tiny payments, the smallest coin pack is $1.99 (200 coins), not $0.99. With the current prices every pack leaves the platform a positive margin after Stripe fees even when creators receive their full 70% share. Free daily check-in coins are paid for by YOU: when a reader spends them on a chapter, the creator still earns their share. Watch this cost.

STEP 1 Create the accounts you need — 10 min

- [ ] GitHub - you already have it. Repository: github.com/Anikettiw-at/web-novel-comic--website-
- [ ] Render - sign up at render.com using "Continue with GitHub".
- [ ] Stripe - sign up at stripe.com (you can stay in Test mode until Step 5).
- [ ] An email provider with SMTP - for example Brevo, Resend, Mailgun or SendGrid (free tiers exist). A Gmail address with an App Password also works for very small volume.
- [ ] Optional but recommended: a domain name from a registrar such as Namecheap, Cloudflare or GoDaddy.

STEP 2 Deploy on Render using the Blueprint — 15 min

- [ ] In Render click New + -> Blueprint.
- [ ] Choose the repository web-novel-comic--website-. Render finds render.yaml automatically and shows one service named "inkverse".
- [ ] When asked for ADMIN_EMAIL type YOUR real email. For ADMIN_PASSWORD type a long unique password (20+ characters) and store it in a password manager.
- [ ] Click Apply / Deploy Blueprint. Wait 3-6 minutes until the service shows "Live".
- [ ] Open the URL Render shows (looks like https://inkverse-xxxx.onrender.com). Click "Log in", use your ADMIN_EMAIL (or username "admin") and the password you chose.
- [ ] You should see the home page (empty catalogue: demo content is intentionally off) and an Admin item in the menu.

If Render says the disk needs a paid plan, choose the Starter instance type. If the build fails, open the Logs tab and compare with the Troubleshooting table at the end.

STEP 3 Tell the app its public address — 3 min

- [ ] In Render open your service -> Environment -> Add Environment Variable.
- [ ] Key PUBLIC_URL, value = your live address WITHOUT a trailing slash, e.g. https://inkverse-xxxx.onrender.com (use your custom domain later in Step 7).
- [ ] Save. Render restarts the service automatically (about 1 minute).

STEP 4 Turn on real email (password reset) — 15 min

In your email provider find "SMTP settings" and copy the values. Then add these variables in Render -> Environment:

Variable	Example value
SMTP_HOST	smtp-relay.brevo.com (use your provider's host)

SMTP_PORT	587
SMTP_USER	the SMTP login your provider shows
SMTP_PASS	the SMTP password / key your provider shows
MAIL_FROM	InkVerse <no-reply@yourdomain.com>

- [ ] Verify the sender address (or domain) inside the email provider - they will tell you exactly which DNS records (SPF/DKIM) to add.
- [ ] Test: log out, click "Forgot your password?", enter an account email, and confirm the email arrives and the link works.

STEP 5 Turn on real payments with Stripe — 30 min + approval time

5a. API key

- [ ] In the Stripe Dashboard stay in Test mode (toggle at top right). Go to Developers -> API keys.
- [ ] Copy the Secret key (starts with sk_test_). In Render -> Environment add STRIPE_SECRET_KEY = that key. Never share it or put it in GitHub.

5b. Webhook (this is what actually credits the coins)

- [ ] Stripe Dashboard -> Developers -> Webhooks -> Add endpoint.
- [ ] Endpoint URL: https://YOUR-ADDRESS/api/stripe/webhook (same address as PUBLIC_URL).
- [ ] Select events: checkout.session.completed, checkout.session.async_payment_succeeded, invoice.paid and customer.subscription.deleted (the last two keep Premium subscriptions in sync). Save.
- [ ] Open the new endpoint and click "Reveal" on Signing secret (starts with whsec_). In Render add STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET = that value.

5c. Test it

- [ ] Log in as a normal reader (register a new account on the site). Open Wallet and click a coin pack - you are sent to Stripe Checkout.
- [ ] Pay with the test card 4242 4242 4242 4242, any future expiry date, any 3-digit CVC, any ZIP.
- [ ] You return to the Wallet and the coins appear within seconds. In Stripe -> Webhooks the delivery should show status 200.
- [ ] If coins do not appear: the signing secret is wrong or PUBLIC_URL/endpoint URL does not match - check Render logs for "Bad signature".

5d. Go live with real money

- [ ] Complete Stripe account activation: business details, identity, and the bank account where money will be paid out.
- [ ] Switch the dashboard to Live mode. Repeat 5a and 5b in Live mode (new sk_live_ key, a NEW live webhook endpoint with its own whsec_ secret).
- [ ] Replace STRIPE_SECRET_KEY and STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET in Render with the live values. Do one real purchase of the cheapest pack yourself and refund it from Stripe if you like.

STEP 6 First-day admin setup — 20 min

- [ ] Log in as admin. Open Admin -> Word filter and add any extra words you want blocked.
- [ ] Register a second account as a Creator (use a different email) and publish a first series and chapter to check the whole flow. Set a price on one chapter, then unlock it from a reader account.

- [ ] Open the Terms and Privacy pages and read them. Replace the contact details and company name by editing public/js/app.js (search for "Terms & Community Guidelines" and "Privacy Policy") and push to GitHub - Render redeploys automatically.
- [ ] Add moderators: have them register normally, then Admin -> Users -> search their username -> "Make moderator". Remove access the same way with "Remove moderator". Moderators have full admin powers (including payouts), so only promote people you trust.

STEP 7 Custom domain and HTTPS

20 min + DNS wait

- [ ] Render -> your service -> Settings -> Custom Domains -> Add Custom Domain, enter yourdomain.com (and www.yourdomain.com).
- [ ] At your domain registrar add the DNS records Render shows (usually a CNAME for www and an A/ALIAS record for the root). Delete conflicting old records.
- [ ] Wait for Render to show "Verified" and issue the free HTTPS certificate (minutes to a few hours).
- [ ] Update PUBLIC_URL in Render to https://yourdomain.com and update the Stripe webhook endpoint URL (both modes) to https://yourdomain.com/api/stripe/webhook.

STEP 8 How to pay your creators (monthly routine)

15 min per cycle

Creators earn money automatically, but the actual transfer is done by you (this keeps the system simple and safe; automatic payouts through Stripe Connect are listed as a future upgrade).

- [ ] Creators add a payout email (PayPal address is simplest) and accept the terms in Studio. They request a payout once available earnings reach $50.
- [ ] Admin -> Payouts shows each request with the amount and payout email.
- [ ] Send the money yourself (PayPal, Wise, bank transfer) for exactly that amount. Keep the receipt.
- [ ] Click "Mark paid" (or "Reject" with a note to the creator). Their balance and a notification update automatically.
- [ ] Each month export or note your totals: coin sales (Stripe), creator payouts, Stripe fees, hosting costs. The Admin overview shows coin sales and creator earnings accrued.

Taxes: if you pay creators, many countries require collecting tax forms (in the US, W-9 for US creators and W-8BEN for foreign ones) and possibly issuing year-end reports. Digital goods can also trigger sales tax or VAT. Talk to an accountant before your first payout; Stripe Tax can help with sales tax/VAT.

STEP 9 Legal checklist

1-2 hours + lawyer time

- [ ] Have a lawyer review the Terms, Privacy Policy and creator payout terms for your country/state. The pages in the app are templates only.
- [ ] Copyright (DMCA): if you serve US users, register a designated DMCA agent with the US Copyright Office (online form, small fee - check the current fee) and put the agent contact on the Copyright page.
- [ ] Children: decide your minimum age. The app asks users to confirm 18+ for mature series; if children can register you may have extra duties (e.g. COPPA in the US, age-appropriate design rules elsewhere).
- [ ] EU/UK users: GDPR applies - add a privacy contact email, a way to export/delete data on request, and list your processors (Render, Stripe, email provider).
- [ ] Child-safety: report any child sexual abuse material immediately to the proper authority (in the US, NCMEC CyberTipline) and remove it. Add image moderation before opening uploads widely.

STEP 10 Backups and monitoring — 15 min

- [ ] The app writes a database backup to /var/data/backups every day and keeps 7 (change with BACKUP_KEEP). This is on the same disk, so it protects against mistakes, not disk loss.
- [ ] In Render open the Disk settings and confirm snapshots are enabled; check Render's current documentation for snapshot retention.
- [ ] Once a week download a copy off-server: Render -> service -> Shell, or ask the developer to add automatic upload to S3/Backblaze (listed in tasks.md).
- [ ] Free uptime monitor: create an UptimeRobot (or similar) HTTP monitor on https://yourdomain.com/api/config with email alerts.
- [ ] Turn on Stripe email alerts for failed webhooks (Developers -> Webhooks).

STEP 11 Pre-launch test script — 30 min

Test	Expected result
Register a reader on your phone	Account created, can browse and read
Forgot password	Email arrives, new password works
Buy the cheapest pack with a test card	Coins appear, Stripe webhook shows 200
Unlock a premium chapter	Coins drop, chapter opens; creator Studio shows pending earnings
Open a chat channel on two devices	Messages appear instantly on both; online counter is 2
Type a blocked word	Message is masked, strike notification arrives
Report a message 3 times from 3 accounts	Message hides and appears in Admin -> Reports
Creator requests payout (needs $50 available; temporarily set HOLD_DAYS=0 to test)	Appears in Admin -> Payouts; "Mark paid" notifies the creator
Restart the Render service	Data and uploaded images are still there (proves the disk works)

STEP 12 Launch and grow — ongoing

- Invite 5-10 creators before inviting readers: a catalogue needs content. Offer launch-month perks such as featured placement.
- Appoint community moderators early and review the report queue daily; reply to appeals within a few days.
- Watch these numbers weekly: new readers, chapters read per reader, % readers who buy coins, creators publishing weekly, report-to-resolution time, payout disputes.
- When traffic grows: move SQLite to PostgreSQL, chat to Redis, images to object storage + CDN (see tasks.md).

Environment variables - complete list

Variable	Required?	Value / where to get it
DATA_DIR	set by blueprint	/var/data (the persistent disk)

UPLOAD_DIR	set by blueprint	/var/data/uploads
SEED_DEMO	set by blueprint	false = no demo users or content
DEMO_PAYMENTS	set by blueprint	false = no free demo coins
JWT_SECRET	auto-generated	Render creates it; do not change after launch (logs everyone out)
ADMIN_EMAIL, ADMIN_PASSWORD	you type at deploy	Your real admin login. ADMIN_USERNAME optional (default admin).
PUBLIC_URL	you add (Step 3)	https://yourdomain.com, no trailing slash
STRIPE_SECRET_KEY	you add (Step 5)	Stripe -> Developers -> API keys (sk_test_ then sk_live_)
STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET	you add (Step 5)	Stripe -> Developers -> Webhooks -> signing secret (whsec_)
SMTP_HOST, SMTP_PORT, SMTP_USER, SMTP_PASS, MAIL_FROM	you add (Step 4)	From your email provider's SMTP page
HOLD_DAYS	optional	Default 14 - days before creator earnings can be withdrawn
BACKUP_KEEP	optional	Default 7 - daily backups kept

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Build fails on Render	Open Logs. Make sure NODE_VERSION=22.12.0 is present and the service root directory is "inkverse".
Site works but chat says "offline"	WebSockets need a normal web service (not static). Check the service type is Web Service and the URL uses https.
Everyone is logged out after each deploy	JWT_SECRET changed or the disk is not mounted. Confirm DATA_DIR=/var/data and the disk exists.
Uploaded images disappear	UPLOAD_DIR must be /var/data/uploads (on the disk).
Pay button says purchases are not enabled	STRIPE_SECRET_KEY is missing, or DEMO_PAYMENTS=false with no Stripe key.
Paid but no coins	Stripe -> Webhooks -> check delivery errors. 400 = wrong signing secret; 503 = secret not set. Fix the variable, then use "Resend" on the event (safe: coins credit only once).
No reset email	Check SMTP variables and the Render logs for "mail error". Verify the sender in your email provider; check spam.
Cannot log in as admin	Admin is created at boot from ADMIN_EMAIL/ADMIN_PASSWORD only if no such user exists. Login with the email or username "admin".
Service sleeps / slow first load	Only on free plans. Use Starter or higher.

Keep your passwords and secret keys in a password manager. Never paste them into chat, email, or GitHub. If a key is ever exposed, roll it immediately in the provider dashboard and update Render.